

GOLDEN HORIZONS



Belize - Caribbean water, white sand, and the slow-retirement rhythm that makes \$2,000/month feel possible.

The 2026 Retirement Abroad Starter Kit

Where your Social Security stretches further - and what to check before you move.

A practical, magazine-style guide to the real costs, honest trade-offs, and next steps for retiring abroad.

golden-horizons.org

How to Use This Guide

Before you read: three things to do.

START HERE

1. COMPARE YOUR BUDGET	Go to Section One first. Find your monthly Social Security income in the affordability table. That tells you which tier of countries is realistic.
2. SHORTLIST 2-3 COUNTRIES	Read the Top 5 Countries and Visa Cheat Sheet. Pick the places that match your budget, health needs, and lifestyle.
3. PLAN A TRIAL VISIT	Use the 10 questions checklist before booking. Most people know within 30 days whether a destination is right.

Warning: Visa rules, income thresholds, healthcare access, and costs change frequently. Always verify with official government sources and consult qualified legal, tax, medical, and financial professionals before making decisions.

“Start with your guaranteed monthly income. Not hope. Not investment upside. Guaranteed income.”

— Editor's Note

SECTION ONE

The Reality Check

What does your Social Security actually buy abroad?

The table below shows what a single person can expect at common Social Security income levels. These are mid-range estimates - not rock bottom, not luxury. Actual costs vary by lifestyle, location, health needs, and inflation.

MONTHLY SS INCOME	TIER	WHAT YOU CAN AFFORD
\$1,200 / month	BUDGET	Comfortable single life in Vietnam, Albania, Ecuador, or Bolivia
\$1,800 / month	COMFORTABLE	Comfortable single life in Colombia, Thailand, Philippines, or Paraguay
\$2,500 / month	STRONG	Single or modest couple in Panama, Costa Rica, Portugal, or Greece

\$3,500+ / month**PREMIUM**Comfortable couple life almost anywhere
on this list

For couples, add roughly 40-60% to single estimates. Two people sharing rent, utilities, and groceries is usually far more efficient than two separate budgets.



Cuenca, Ecuador - Andean calm, springlike weather, and a budget that can still breathe.

SECTION TWO

Top 5 Countries Under \$2,000/Month

Real options for real budgets.

These five countries offer a comfortable single-person lifestyle for under \$2,000/month in many cities. All can be realistic for Social Security-funded retirees, but the right choice depends on healthcare, visa rules, language, climate, and risk tolerance.

EC #1 – Ecuador

LATIN AMERICA · USD ECONOMY · FASTEST CITIZENSHIP



Ecuador - volcano country, colonial streets, and one of the strongest value cases in the Americas.

DESTINATION SNAPSHOT	
BEST FOR	Retirees who want a USD economy, perfect climate, and a path to citizenship in about 3 years.
MONTHLY ESTIMATE	~\$1,200-\$1,500/month for a single person.
VISA SHORTCUT	\$1,446/month guideline based on 3x SBU of \$482; Social Security often accepted; online application.
WATCH OUT FOR	Security varies by region. Cuenca remains a stronger retiree fit; Spanish is important; specialized care may require Quito.
GOLDEN HORIZONS VERDICT	The best-value destination in the Americas for budget retirees seeking climate, simplicity, and affordability.

EXPENSE	ESTIMATE
1-BR Apartment (Cuenca)	\$400-\$600
Groceries	\$200-\$300
Dining Out	\$150-\$200
Private Health Insurance	\$80-\$150
Utilities + Internet	\$70-\$110

co #2 - Colombia - Medellin

SOUTH AMERICA · ETERNAL SPRING · JCI HOSPITALS



Colombia - mountain-green landscapes and Medellin healthcare access at a fraction of US costs.

DESTINATION SNAPSHOT	
BEST FOR	Couples on a tight-to-moderate budget seeking strong healthcare and vibrant expat life.
MONTHLY ESTIMATE	~\$1,500-\$2,200/month for a couple.
VISA SHORTCUT	~\$1,350-\$1,400/month pension threshold; Social Security accepted with proper documentation; online process.
WATCH OUT FOR	Research neighborhoods carefully. Private health insurance can add \$200-\$350/month for a couple.
GOLDEN HORIZONS VERDICT	Excellent value for couples. Medellin combines hospital access, spring weather, and strong lifestyle upside.

EXPENSE	ESTIMATE
2-BR Apartment	\$700-\$950
Groceries	\$300-\$400

Dining Out	\$200-\$300
Insurance	\$200-\$350
Utilities + Internet	\$90-\$140

VN #3 - Vietnam - Da Nang

SE ASIA · LOWEST COST · BEACH CITY VALUE



Vietnam - market mornings, beach cities, and the lowest-cost lifestyle in this guide.

DESTINATION SNAPSHOT

BEST FOR	Ultra-budget retirees who want maximum purchasing power in Asia.
MONTHLY ESTIMATE	~\$1,000-\$1,400/month for a single person.
VISA SHORTCUT	90-day e-visa; renewable routes vary; no dedicated retirement visa.
WATCH OUT FOR	Verify Social Security payment eligibility and visa continuity before committing. Major procedures may require travel.
GOLDEN HORIZONS VERDICT	One of the most affordable quality-of-life destinations in the world, especially for food, internet, and rent.

EXPENSE

ESTIMATE

1-BR Apartment	\$350-\$500
Groceries	\$120-\$180
Dining Out	\$100-\$180
Private Health Insurance	\$80-\$120
Utilities + Internet	\$60-\$100

AL #4 – Albania

EUROPE • CHEAPEST EU-ADJACENT OPTION • 1-YEAR VISA-FREE



Albania - dramatic mountain villages and Europe-adjacent scenery without Western Europe pricing.

DESTINATION SNAPSHOT

BEST FOR	Retirees who want European scenery and lifestyle without European prices.
MONTHLY ESTIMATE	~\$900-\$1,300/month for a single person.
VISA SHORTCUT	Americans may stay up to 1 year visa-free; longer stays require in-country planning.
WATCH OUT FOR	No US-Albania tax treaty may create complexity. Healthcare is stronger in Tirana than smaller towns.

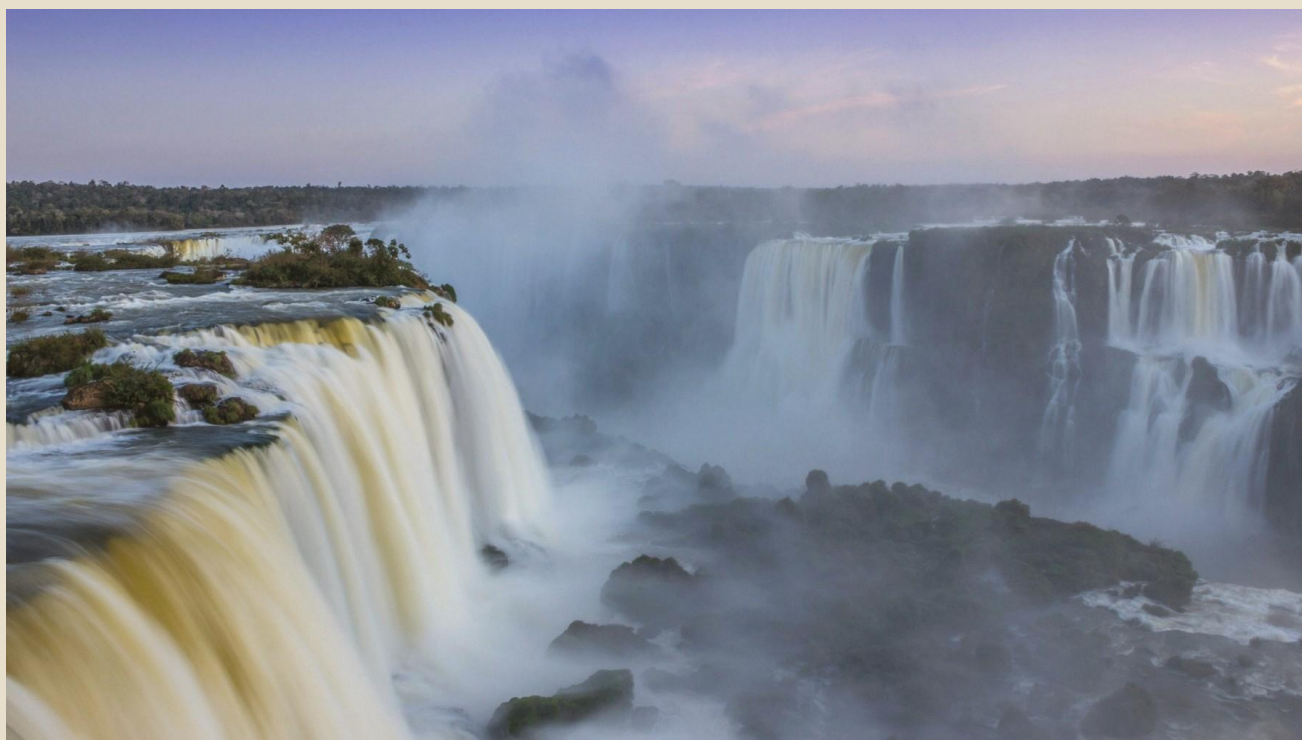
GOLDEN HORIZONS VERDICT

Europe's cheapest coastal-feeling option, ideal for a long trial visit before any commitment.

EXPENSE	ESTIMATE
1-BR Apartment	\$250-\$450
Groceries	\$120-\$200
Dining Out	\$80-\$160
Private Health Insurance	\$80-\$140
Utilities + Internet	\$60-\$100

PY #5 - Paraguay

SOUTH AMERICA · FOREIGN-INCOME TAX ADVANTAGE · FLEXIBLE RESIDENCY



Paraguay - South American openness, low living costs, and flexible residency appeal.

DESTINATION SNAPSHOT

BEST FOR	Tax-aware retirees seeking an affordable and flexible residency path in South America.
MONTHLY ESTIMATE	~\$1,000-\$1,400/month for a single person.

VISA SHORTCUT	Social Security may support proof-of-income strategy; local lawyer often helpful.
WATCH OUT FOR	Spanish matters. English-speaking community is smaller. Healthcare infrastructure is best in Asuncion.
GOLDEN HORIZONS VERDICT	Best for flexibility and tax minimization, but less turnkey than Panama, Ecuador, or Colombia.

EXPENSE	ESTIMATE
1-BR Apartment	\$300-\$500
Groceries	\$150-\$220
Dining Out	\$100-\$180
Private Health Insurance	\$80-\$140
Everything Else	\$150-\$250

SECTION THREE

The Visa Cheat Sheet

One top pick from every retirement region.

These are planning notes, not legal advice. Use them to shortlist destinations, then verify current requirements with official government sources or a qualified immigration professional.



Portugal - Atlantic cliffs, old-world towns, and a European retirement path that rewards careful planning.

COUNTRY	REGION	MIN. INCOME	PROCESSING	SS ACCEPTED	TAX NOTE	PATH
P A Panama	Latin America	\$1,000/mo	4-6 months	Yes	None	Immediate PR path
P T Portugal	Europe	€920/mo	3-6 months	Yes	Complex	5 years
T H Thailand	SE Asia	~\$1,825/mo	2-4 weeks	Yes	Complex after 2024 changes	Difficult
B Z Belize	Caribbean	\$2,000/mo	1-3 months	Yes	None	QRP only
C O Colombia	South America	~\$1,400/mo	2-4 weeks	Yes	Generally favorable for pension income	5 years

“Colombia's roughly \$1,400/month pension visa is one of the lowest thresholds in Latin America – and it can accept US Social Security with proper documentation.”

— Golden Horizons · 2026 Visa Analysis



Panama City - dollar economy, modern skyline, and one of the classic US-retiree routes.

SECTION FOUR

10 Questions to Ask Before You Go

The questions most people forget until it's too late.

1. Can I receive my Social Security in this country?

The SSA restricts payments to residents of certain countries. Check the official SSA country-payment rules before making plans.

2. What if I get seriously ill?

Know where you would go for surgery, cancer treatment, or a serious accident. Budget for international health insurance and evacuation coverage.

3. Do I need a lawyer or local agent?

Some countries are easier with professional help. Budget \$500-\$2,000 for immigration assistance where appropriate.

4. What about US taxes?

US citizens generally remain subject to US tax rules on worldwide income. Speak with a US expat tax specialist before leaving.

5. What happens to my Medicare?

Medicare usually does not cover care outside the United States. Confirm your backup plan and private insurance options.



Thailand - beach towns, expat hospitals, and a daily-life rhythm many Americans test first.

6. Can I bring my medications?

Check controlled-substance rules and local availability for anything you take regularly.

7. How will I manage my money?

Plan bank access, ATM fees, wire transfers, exchange rates, and emergency backup cards.

8. What is the minimum stay requirement?

Some visas require physical presence. Know the rule before long trips back to the US.

9. How will I stay connected to family?

Build annual flights home into the budget. Shorter US flight access can matter more than people expect.

10. Have I done a trial run?

Spend 1-3 months first. Rent an apartment, shop locally, use healthcare, and live a normal week - not a vacation week.



Cuenca, Ecuador - a practical trial-run base for budget-focused retirees who want climate and culture.

Your 3-Step Next Move

A simple roadmap from curious to committed.

TIMING	MOVE	ACTION
MONTH 1	Pick 3 Countries	Use the affordability table. Read the country profiles. Pick 2-3 destinations that fit your income, healthcare needs, and lifestyle.
MONTHS 2-3	Compare Visas + Healthcare	Verify current visa requirements, identify the nearest private hospital, and price health insurance with evacuation coverage.
MONTHS 4-6	Book a Trial Visit	Spend 4-8 weeks in your top country. Rent an apartment, shop in local markets, visit the hospital, and test daily life.

“The trial visit is the most important step. Most people know within 30 days whether a country is right for them.”

— Golden Horizons · Retirement Planning Guide



Da Nang, Vietnam - quiet coast, street-food value, and a total budget that can stay near \$1,200/month.

Your Next Step

You don't have to figure this out alone.

Every day, Golden Horizons sends one short email covering a real retirement destination - the costs, the visa, the lifestyle, and the honest trade-offs. No hype. No pressure. Just the information you need to make a good decision at your own pace.

READER NOTES	
SUBSCRIBER	I had no idea Colombia was so affordable. I booked a trial visit after reading three issues.
SUBSCRIBER	The visa cheat sheet alone was worth subscribing. I finally understood what I actually qualify for.
SUBSCRIBE FREE	golden-horizons.org

“The dream of retiring somewhere warm, affordable, and beautiful is more realistic than you think – and we will show you exactly how.”

— Golden Horizons

This guide is for informational purposes only and does not constitute legal, financial, tax, immigration, medical, or investment advice. Requirements and costs change frequently. Verify current requirements with official government sources and qualified professionals before making decisions.

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